flaunting the new treaty as a triumph. As Roos-Keppel's secretary noted, 'a General Sarsarus has been saying that Afghanistan got the main things it wanted, independence and certain tracts of land and that others – importation of arms, subsidy and better treatment of Indians – had been postponed until excitement in India had subsided'.[168] Thus, while the Indian government believed that by the treaty it had taught Afghanistan its place, 'the position of a petty state in relation to her powerful neighbour',[169] Montagu had to point out that:

The fact remains that a great deal of disquiet was felt here by myself and my colleagues, and has been shared, as I must assure you, by that part of the public which takes an informed interest in Afghanistan, as to whether the Afghans, under what may have been a show of bluff, have ever truly realised that they were not the victors.[170]

Ultimately, however, in a role reversal (which was perhaps apt considering the situation in Persia), there was little Montagu (or Curzon) could do once Chelmsford had decided on his course but to impotently complain that his opinion was not valued by the Indian government.

Blown Sky High

By August of 1919, the British government had concluded two new treaties with two of the most important nations bordering its imperial field of interest, each one reflecting the views of the main negotiators on Britain's future in southern Asia. The Anglo-Persian Agreement represented the 'iron hand' of Curzon and his allies, while the Anglo-Afghan treaty was a demonstration of the Indian government's preference for the 'velvet glove'. When it came to Persia, Curzon's thinking was conditioned by his Great Game experience which placed Russia front and centre in his considerations. Yet whether it was the new Bolshevik regime in Moscow or